The 1916 Easter Rising

The Easter Rising was an armed insurrection that took place in Ireland during Easter Week, April 24–29, 1916. Organized mainly by the Irish Republican Brotherhood, alongside members of the Irish Volunteers and the socialist Citizen Army led by James Connolly, it was a bold attempt to end British rule in Ireland and establish an independent republic. Though ultimately unsuccessful as a military operation, the Rising became a defining moment in Irish history.

The rebellion was carefully planned but poorly resourced. Around 1,200 rebels seized key positions in Dublin, including the General Post Office (GPO), which became their headquarters. Patrick Pearse read the Proclamation of the Irish Republic outside the GPO, declaring the establishment of a sovereign Irish Republic. Other leaders included Thomas Clarke, Seán Mac Diarmada, Éamonn Ceannt, Joseph Plunkett, and James Connolly, many of whom would later be executed for their roles.

Fighting broke out across Dublin as British forces moved to suppress the Rising. The rebels held out for nearly a week, facing artillery bombardment and vastly superior numbers of soldiers. Civilian casualties were tragically high—over 250 civilians were killed, many caught in the crossfire. Approximately 130 British soldiers and police officers died, alongside around 60 rebels. By April 29, with central Dublin in ruins and supplies running out, Pearse ordered a surrender.

At first, public opinion in Ireland was hostile to the rebels, seeing them as reckless for staging an uprising during World War I. However, this sentiment shifted dramatically after the British executed 15 of the leaders over a ten-day period in May 1916. The executions, along with the harsh treatment of prisoners, generated sympathy for the rebels and helped transform them into martyrs for Irish independence.

The Easter Rising laid the groundwork for the later War of Independence (1919–1921). While it failed to achieve its immediate aim, it succeeded in reviving Irish republicanism and inspiring a new generation of nationalists. Today, it is remembered as a turning point in the struggle for Irish freedom and a pivotal moment that led, eventually, to the establishment of the Irish Free State in 1922.